

IASH Talk

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Introduction

This talk is centered around Fordism - the particular set of social and productive relations that were developed by the early automotive industrial pioneers in the first decades of the 20th century: both Henry Ford and his competitors in the US Midwest. In their drive to produce cars more and more efficiently, and in their ambition of making the car a general consumer good, they remade the working class into a more efficient producer and a more extensive consumer of commodities. Indeed, this combined interest in reconfiguring both the productive and consumptive sphere is the defining attribute of Fordism. Much of the literature on Fordism and its affects on the working classes limit it geographically - first to the automotive workers of the Midwest, whence it spread to the rest of the country and finally to Europe by midcentury. According to this dominant narrative, Fordism did not reach the Global South until the US was deindustrializing; by this time it had been shorn of its original stimulus to consumption, reduced to an extreme rationalization and degradation of labor. My contention in this paper is that contrary to this narrative, Fordism in fact had an immediate and severe effect on the workers of the Third World. The exponential increase in the demand for rubber disrupted and reshaped the productive and consumptive patterns of life among rubber workers, as companies resorted to debt bondage, violence, slavery and outright genocide in their drive to meet demand. This talk will focus on the case of the Putumayo Genocide, in which the Peruvian Amazon Company enslaved and massacred tens of thousands of indigenous people in the rubber producing region of the Andes.

There are two things I want to note before getting into the talk. Firstly, the research that I'm presenting is very much in its early stages. Mapping out the global commodity chains that fed Fordist production is one thing, but connecting this to a global analysis of the social lives of workers is more fraught, and I'm very much still working through this. I would appreciate any comments on either the theoretical or empirical nature of this problem. Secondly, the details of the Putumayo Genocide are rather upsetting. While I won't be dwelling on its graphic detail, I want to put a content warning out there in advance.

The Automotive Industry

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Automotive production expanded rapidly in the first quarter of the 20th century. In 1900, the US produced 4,192 cars, and in 1929 reached a peak production of 5,337,087. Production declined thereafter due to the Great Depression, and this number would not be matched until after the war, in 1948. Throughout this time, the US was by far the dominant global producer of automobiles; indeed it was only surpassed in 1980, by Japan.¹ As cars became more and more integrated into the daily lives of most US Americans, they were accompanied by a profound shift in the structures of society.

During this period, cities became more spread out as workers began to live in suburbs or neighborhoods some distance from their workplaces. Further, thanks to several innovations in the production process, such as the moving assembly line, automotive production was quite profitable and the higher wages paid to some workers allowed them to become homeowners, and to form nuclear families organized around a single wage-earner. Many of these changes were promoted by automotive

¹*World Motor Vehicle Data* (Motor Vehicle Manufacturers Association of the United States, Inc., 1982).

manufacturers themselves: General Motors built homes and sold them directly to employees (often at a loss), and the Ford Motor Company provided their employees with favorable financing for mortgages. Although several automotive companies in Michigan were involved in actively promoting a transformation of both production practices and American social life, Henry Ford led the charge and the collection of social and productive transformations among auto companies and their employees have come to be called 'Fordism'.

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The Fordist worker stands out in history as the perfect specimen of capitalism's working class - a true Proletarian. In his family life, he is fully divorced from the means of subsistence. His wife does not keep boarders or take in laundry to supplement their income, because the family is provided for solely from the husband's five dollar wage. In the factory, every day looks like a scene ripped straight out of Marx's *Capital* - the laborer reduced to an automaton, endlessly repeating rote tasks in place while the machines take to life and rove about the shop floor. Capital - the mass of past, dead labor congeals into machines that rule over the living labor of the wage worker.

This Fordist worker is the result of what Gramsci refers to as an attempt to "elaborate a new kind of man suited to the new type of work and productive process."² For Gramsci, Fordism operated alongside another process he called 'Americanism' - a process of cultural consolidation and socialization that extended beyond the shop floor, but which was oriented towards it. Americanism aimed to take the heterogeneous working classes of the American Midwest and build a unified labor force. For Gramsci one of the reasons American industry was so productive in the early 20th century was America's "rational demographic composition" in which "there do not exist numerous classes with no essential function in the world of production," such as a clergy class, or the "fossilisation of civil-service personnel and intellectuals" that existed in Europe.³ During the early years of the auto industry the population of the Midwest was rapidly growing - largely fed by former peasants from eastern Europe and Black workers from the American south. As European immigrants arrived in the US they were severed from previous traditional and personal connections. They arrived as atomized individuals (or families) that were isolated from both the responsibilities and privileges of their social location in Europe. Obviously upon arrival they often joined or created communities among themselves - for example there were German and Polish language newspapers published in Michigan throughout the 20th century and in to the 21st. But to a very great degree they were isolated from traditional social structures. Automotive companies saw an opportunity to step in and fill the gap - and to direct the development of working class culture to their own ends.

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The phrase "a new kind of man" is a little misleading. In their article entitled "The Detroit Story: the crucible of Fordism," Joan Smith and Kathleen Stanley question the extent to which the family wage was ever generalized among workers in the region. They note that in the 1890s, wages in Detroit were lower than the national average. This was partly due to the depressed wages of immigrants who made up close to 70% of the city, and due to the relatively large percentage of the workforce that were women. While noting that there was much variation among family incomes, they cite that "The [average] laborer whose budget was reported by the Michigan Bureau of Labor, for example, faced an annual shortfall of \$86, or 27 percent of his total income."⁴ Over a third of the city's workforce was

²Antonio Gramsci, *Selections from the Prison Notebooks*, trans. Hoare Quintin and Geoffrey Nowell Smith (International Publishers Co, 1971), 286

³Gramsci, *Selections from the Prison Notebooks*, 281

⁴Kathleen Stanley and Joan Smith. 1992. "The Detroit Story: the crucible of Fordism," in *Creating and Transforming Households: the constraints of the world-economy*, eds. Joan Smith and Immanuel Wallerstein. Cambridge University Press, 36.

made up of “semiskilled, unskilled, and service workers” who earned considerably less than this average.

After the development of the Five-Dollar Day in 1914, household patterns in Detroit changed, but not necessarily in the direction of single-income homes. Stanley and Smith note that in the decades following Ford’s family-wage campaign, “even in Detroit, this presumed bastion of Fordism, the family wage was never a reality for the majority of wage-earners.” Except for a small elite strata of the working classes, “the male wage was always supplemented by the wages of children and sometimes of wives, as well as by considerable amounts of subsistence labor.”⁵ This picture looks much the same as pre-Fordist Detroit, so what changed? Was the social transformation of Fordism as radical as its labor transformation?

In short, yes, but to understand exactly how we need to look more closely at patterns of race. Between 1900 and 1940, the population of Michigan more than doubled, from 2.4 million to 5.3 million. During this same period, the Black population of the state increased by a factor of more than *thirteen*, from just over 15,000 to more than 208, 000.⁶ Most of this increase was driven by Black migrants from the southern states, looking for better working conditions and wages in the industrial Midwest.

To an extent they were able to find them, but they did not enter the Michigan workforce on equal footing with whites. According to the 1930 census, Black men were significantly overrepresented in low paid manufacturing jobs, while their white counterparts were more often employed either as shop foremen or skilled machinists.⁷ The cities themselves mirrored this, with white workers more often owning free standing homes in newly developed neighborhoods, and Black workers and poor whites confined to slums. In other words, the social significance of Fordism was defined as much by who it excluded from prosperity as by who it included.

In the context of this exclusion of Black workers and families from the benefits that Fordism afforded its workers, perhaps a better phrase than 'elaboration of a new kind of man' is the 'elaboration of new kinds of men' or even 'new kinds of families' - for the effect of Fordism was not a uniformly elevated working class, but a newly stratified working class with benefits for some supported by the exclusion of others. The Fordist project was predicated on a racial division of labor in which the work of 'devalued' and racialized subjects propped up the too-prevalent image of the all-American working class family. However, this division of labor was not limited to the local labor market. As we look down the commodity chain at the raw material inputs, especially rubber from the Global South, we see that the racial division of Fordist labor was a global one.

The Rubber Industry

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I would like now to turn to the main argument of my dissertation project: the global scope of this dynamic. I assert that Fordism not only effected a stratification of the local labor market, but of the global labor force. In this next section I will examine how the rise of the automotive industry created enormous demand for rubber, and how the lives of workers in the rubber producing regions of the Global South were reshaped by this demand.

Between 1900 and 1935, the annual global production of rubber grew from 44 thousand long tonnes to over one million. This 25x increase was largely driven by the growth of the automotive industry, which required a continuous input of cheap rubber as cars grew from niche luxury goods into a near necessity for much of the Global North. [Slide 6] At the start of the century, more than half of

⁵Stanley and Smith, “The Detroit Story,” 34.

⁶US Census Bureau. *Michigan*. 1940

⁷US Census Bureau. *Michigan*. 1930

the global rubber market was supplied by the Amazon Valley, 26,000 long tonnes out of 44. This rubber was almost exclusively produced from wild rubber trees, harvested by roaming tappers. Just over a third of a century later, Amazonian rubber production had fallen to 15k long tonnes, or just over a percent of the global total. The center of the rubber world had shifted to Southeast Asia - primarily to what is now Malaysia, but also to Indonesia and parts of India. Instead of collecting wild rubber from the vast jungle, tappers in Asia were working on plantations operating under a vast colonial apparatus that spanned the Bay of Bengal.

What caused this shift? Why did rubber fail in its native region, the Amazon, and flourish on a set of islands thousands of miles away? For the first decade of the 20th century, Amazonian production grew - in 1912 it reached a peak of 41,000 tonnes. It then halved over the next decade and halved again the decade after that. The causes were several. In some cases, rubber workers resisted the demand for increased production, in other cases the workers were massacred at the whim of rubber company employees. Finally, attempts to establish plantations in the Amazon were stymied by the South American leaf blight, which spread rapidly through regions where rubber trees were planted close together. Chief among these reasons, however, were the destructive methods used to meet the quickly rising demand. Both humans and nature were trampled underfoot in the quest for what came to be called the 'Devil's milk'.

Humans have used rubber in some fashion for thousands of years. It was used by Mesoamerican peoples to make bottles, balls or waterproof shoes. Despite this, in the 19th century the rubber industry in Europe and the US mainly provided products with limited industrial practicality until the development of the vulcanization process in the late 1830s. Vulcanization allowed for the creation of stable and hardened rubber industrial products, and by 1845 carriage wheels were equipped with solid rubber tires.⁸ Tire production, along with rubber insulation for electrical wires, drove the rubber industry to new heights. In the US, the rubber industry was centered in Ohio - by 1900 Akron was the home to Goodrich, Goodyear, and Firestone. Business was good and all three were multi-million dollar companies by 1910. Firestone was especially successful, thanks to exclusive contracts with Ford to provide tires to the Model N in 1906 and to the famous Model T in 1908.⁹ Fortunes were made in the manufacture and sale of tires, but down the commodity chain the story was quite different.

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Industrial harvesting of rubber began in the Amazon and central Africa in the 1800s, where latex producing plants grew natively. Bunker and Ciccantell claim that since “the Amazon provided the technically most useful and abundant kinds of rubber in the world, states and firms in the rapidly industrializing, trade-dominant nations of Europe and America were particularly interested and active in the Amazon.”¹⁰ Initial production consisted of wild-collection by contract laborers. Although plantations would dominate the global rubber production by the second decade of the twentieth century, for the first several decades of the auto industry there were few rationalized rubber plantations, and rubber had to be sourced from wild collectors, mostly in the Amazon but notoriously also in the Congo.

The working conditions in rubber fields in the Amazon were a world away from those in the US. Whereas factory production in the US was almost exclusively run on wage labor, during the Amazon rubber boom, three distinct modes of labor existed alongside each other: wage labor (which was very uncommon), debt bondage, and slavery. The rubber workers of the Amazon were differentiated by several historical processes. Factors of environment and geography, social factors such as the ongoing construction of racial categories, and inter-state politics all contributed to shaping

⁸Coates, Austin. 1987. *Commerce in Rubber: The First 250 Years*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 49

⁹Coates, *Commerce in Rubber*, 134

¹⁰Stephen G. Bunker and Paul S. Ciccantell, *Globalization and the Race for Resources* (Johns Hopkins University Press, 2005), 39

the work forces of Amazonian rubber tappers. In some areas of the Amazon, rubber was tapped by former agricultural workers from the Ceará region, who had been forced to leave their homes by a drought in the 1870s.¹¹ The workers from Ceará mostly labored under debt-peonage, their passage to the rubber regions paid for by the companies - they started work with a negative balance that would prove hard to pay off. The more remote regions of the Amazon, and those where rubber was of inferior quality - in other words in regions where profits were slim - indigenous populations were enslaved and forced to gather rubber in the shadow of the lash and gun.

The Putumayo Genocide

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The remainder of this presentation will focus on a particular case which shows these dynamics in sharp relief. I will discuss the Putumayo Genocide and the conditions of slavery in the rubber industry of the Putumayo Basin during the first decade of the 20th century. This part of the talk presents preliminary results from my research over the summer when I was able to view the papers of the British Anti-Slavery Society, held in the Bodleian Library at Oxford.

The Putumayo River is a tributary of the Amazon river which forms the current border between Colombia and Peru. The river basin is the traditional home of several indigenous peoples: the Huitoto were the most numerous, but there were other groups as well, such as the Bora and Muinane people. In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the land north of the river was claimed by both Peru and Colombia, each of whom sent 'settlers' into the area to establish land claims and harvest its rubber. Rubber was booming, and there was certainly a fortune to be made in its exploitation, but we should note that the rubber of the Putumayo region was of an inferior quality. In addition to the well-known *Hevea Brasiliensis*, which can be tapped, the region was also home to the lower quality *Castilloa Elastica*, which was cut down in the process of harvesting its natural latex. Evidently harvesting was so severe that a contemporary observer in 1907 noted that Colombian harvesters complained there was very little of this second type left.¹² The poor quality of the region's rubber required production costs to be kept low in order that the product might be viable on the world market. Both Colombian and Peruvian companies operating in the region relied heavily on the local indigenous population to perform the actual work of harvesting the latex.

The working conditions were brutal, beyond imagining. Throughout the Putumayo basin, indigenous people were enslaved, compelled to labor as rubber tappers, and massacred in great numbers. In what was known at the time as the Putumayo atrocities, but which is now called the Putumayo Genocide, tens of thousands of the indigenous inhabitants of the region were killed. One of the groups targeted, the Muinane people, were reduced from 2000 to just 20 as a result of the massacres. In 1993, their descendants in the Muinane census still numbered less than 150.¹³ Exact figures are disputed, but Roger Casement gives a conservative estimate of 30,000 total victims; the Putumayo region was depopulated by 90% during the rubber boom. The majority of the contemporary documentation of the genocide comes from three sources: the articles of Peruvian journalist Benjamin Saldaña Rocca, the engineer and adventurer W.E. Hardenburg who traveled to Putumayo in search of fortune in 1907 and published an account of his journey in 1912, and the Irishman Roger Casement who traveled to the Putumayo on behalf of the British Government in 1910, and who was first knighted

¹¹Louise Cardoso de Mello and Sven Van Melkebeke, "From the Amazon to the Congo Valley: A Comparative Study on the Violent Commodification of Labour During the Rubber Boom (1870s–1910s)," in *Commodity Frontiers and Global Capitalist Expansion*, ed. Sabrina Joseph, Palgrave Studies in Economic History (Palgrave MacMillon, 2019), 160

¹²W. E. Hardenburg, *The Putumayo: The Devil's Paradise*, ed. C. R. Enock (T. Fisher Unwin, 1912), 94-5

¹³Juan Alvaro Echeverri, "The Putumayo Indians and the Rubber Boom," *Irish Journal of Anthropology* 14, no. 2 (2011): 13–18.

for his advocacy of the victims of colonialism in Peru and the Congo, and later executed for running guns to Irish revolutionaries.

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The primary perpetrators of the Putumayo Genocide were the Peruvian agents of the J. C. Arana and Hermanos Company, which was, with an investment of British capital, renamed the Peruvian Amazon Company in 1907 (hereafter PAC). Originally a hat salesman, Julio César Arana began to work with small Colombian rubber interests in the late 1890s, and in 1903 started his own rubber company along with his brothers-in-law. He soon bought out his Colombian partners and attempted to push out the remainder of the Colombian competitors. Arana and co were ruthless - when dealing with former partners, Arana "[took] advantage of their ignorance and stupidity to rob them scandalously," in the words of W.E. Hardenburg.¹⁴ When cunning was insufficient, Arana "forced José Cabrera, owner of Nueva Granada, to sell out to them at an insignificant price by threats of killing him, by shooting at him from ambush, by forcibly taking away his Indians [sic], and by the other methods for which this company is known."¹⁵

There is something significant in Hardenburg using the phrase "taking away his Indians" that we will return to, but for now it's enough to note that over time Arana's methods became more and more terrible. While Hardenburg was visiting Colombian rubber estates in the Putumayo he heard stories of Arana's men attacking his white competitors, murdering their workers, enslaving their children and raping their wives. The PAC conducted raids on independent estates to frighten them out of the region and to steal their rubber stores. In some cases they appear to have been accompanied by Peruvian soldiers, evidently there to enforce Peru's claim to the region.

Hardenburg and his traveling companions were captured in one of these raids and held for some days at one of Arana's estates. It was here that he realized the extent of Arana's criminality. Their violence was not aimed only at competitors, but was directed against the local indigenous population as well. Whereas the Colombian rubber harvesters had paid the native workers - underpaid, to be sure, and often in commodities rather than direct wages - the agents of the Peruvian Amazon Company compelled local indigenous groups to collect rubber by force. Slavery is the obvious term for this, but what was described by Hardenburg and then corroborated by the testimonies Casement collected later went far beyond a system of forcibly extracting labor from unfree subjects. It was a regime of terror. The indigenous Huitoto were forced to collect rubber and were provided only the barest amount of food. If they failed to collect enough rubber they were punished severely, and not only the men, but the women and children all bore the scars of the lash, which came to be known as the "marca de Arana."¹⁶ When they grew too old or sick to work they were killed and fed to dogs. Beyond this, the company officers kept harems of girls as young as nine whom they raped and killed at will; they used children as target practice, or lit them on fire for amusement.

What was the purpose of this horror? The contemporary accounts are shot through with attempts to make sense of something so offensive to sense and reason. Casement makes the argument in his report that the enslavement of the Huitoto people and their terrorization was a response by the Peruvian Amazon Company to the condition of labor scarcity in the region. Due to the expense of transporting the rubber from the Putumayo to market, Casement says that the "company resorted to the use of forced labour under a debt-peonage system, and used torture to maintain labour discipline."¹⁷ But as Michael Taussig claims, this, while not incorrect, can only be a partial explanation, as "terror and torture do not

¹⁴Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 200

¹⁵Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 200

¹⁶Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 179-80

¹⁷Michael Taussig, "Culture of Terror--Space of Death. Roger Casement's Putumayo Report and the Explanation of Torture," *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 26, no. 3 (1984), 479

derive only from market pressure (which we can regard here as a trigger) but also from the process of cultural construction of evil as well."¹⁸ Indeed, the violence employed by the PAC was not only directed at the workers, but at their entire communities, and in fact it undermined the workforce by starving, maiming, and ultimately slaughtering thousands of would-be rubber tappers.

So again: what was the purpose of this horror? Taussig's analysis of this question sheds light on our initial concern with the transformation of the lives of rubber workers. The elaboration, not only of a new kind of man, but of a new kind of family and a new kind of society. He places the terror of the Putumayo within the context of the "construction of colonial reality that occurred in the New World... where the Indian and the African became subject to an initially far smaller number of Christians."¹⁹ Terror played a fundamental role in this construction: terror "which as well as being a physiological state is also a social fact and a cultural construction whose baroque dimensions allow it to serve as the mediator *par excellence* of colonial hegemony."²⁰

The construction of colonial hegemony goes back a long way, and the actions of the Peruvian Amazon Company, which Hardenburg ironically calls the 'civilising company', can be seen in a sense as a continuation of the Valladolid debate: an attempt by European conquering powers to, as Jason Moore says "justify and enable the profit-driven conquest, appropriation, and exploitation of humans and the rest of nature so as to sustain the endless accumulation of capital."²¹ This was indeed a Civilising Project by a "civilising company" in that it was an attempt to impose a civilizational order that not only extracted cheap labor from its racialized subjects, but that actively devalued both indigenous populations and their ways of life, as well as the natural world.

But the perpetrators of genocide were not the only participants in the construction of colonial hegemony, though they may have been its most grotesque face. Indeed, many of the liberal humanitarians who were instrumental in exposing and stopping the genocide were also invested in the same civilising project - their difference of opinion with the PAC lay in the means, not the ends. I would now like to make a closer reading of some of the early publications that exposed the genocide and called for intervention. For the moment we will bracket and set aside Roger Casement and Benjamin Saldaña Rocca and focus on Hardenburg's account in *The Devil's Paradise*, as edited and introduced by C. Reginald Enock.

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Enock's introduction to Hardenburg's account is an interesting document. Enock was a mining engineer who wrote several books about his travels through South America, and who, according to his obituary, "spent much of his life expounding an economic system based on Christian principles."²² Indeed, his introduction is full of righteous anger and denunciations of the anti-Christian conduct done "under a republican Government in a Christianised country, at the behest of the agents of a great joint-stock company with headquarters in London."²³ He condemns the system in which "In order to obtain rubber so that the luxurious-tyred motor-cars of civilisation might multiply in the cities of Christendom, the dismal forests of the Amazon have echoed with the cries of despairing and tortured Indian aborigines."²⁴ For him there is a great irony in the poor conduct of the Christians towards a people that he says "[i]n general are docile and have good qualities; they are naturally free from

¹⁸Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 479

¹⁹Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 468

²⁰Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 468

²¹Jason W. Moore, "Our Capitalogenic World: Climate Crises, Class Politics, and the Civilizing Project," *Annales Universitatis Paedagogicae Cracoviensis. Studia Poetica* 11 (2023), 98

²²*West Sussex Gazette*, 9th June 1949, accessed at http://www.enockfamilyhistory.co.uk/Charles_Reginald_Enock_-_1869-1970.htm

²³Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 12

²⁴Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 12

immorality and disease; they have a strong affection for their women and children and a regard for the aged." In the next sentence, however, he lets slip his mask: The people of the Putumayo are "well worthy of preservation, and might have been a valuable asset to the region."²⁵

Enock's christian brotherliness only goes so far. The peoples of the Putumayo are "worthy of preservation" in so far as they are docile and free from immorality. He projects an explicit framework of classification in which some peoples are more valued than others. He initially rejects the racialization of the indigenous Putumayans, saying that "[t]hese people, although known as *infieles* and *salvages* - that is, 'un-faithed' and 'savage' - cannot be described as savages in the ordinary sense of the term. They have nothing in common with the bloody savages of Africa and other parts of the world." Even his praise is built on the devaluation of other races, but faint as it is he cannot hold onto it for long. A mere two pages later he attempts to describe the various peoples in Peru, saying "[t]he highland and coast people were those who formed the population under the Inca government, and under whose control they had reached a high degree of aboriginal civilisation; whilst the indigenes of the forests were more or less roving bands of savages, dwelling on the river banks, without other forms of government than that of the *curacas*, or petty chiefs of families or tribe." As evidence of the virtue of the people in the coastal region, Enock says they live under an intelligible structure, in which "every village contains its *iglesia* and village priest."²⁶ In perhaps the most bizarre expression of his racial calculus, Enock develops an explanation of why the Peruvian 'Christians' would commit such terrible crimes, and why the English stockholders should to some extent be exudes. To quote somewhat at length:

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"Apart from topographical considerations, the sinister occurrences on the Putumayo are, to some extent, the result of a sinister human element - the Spanish and Portuguese character. The remarkable trait of callousness to human suffering which the Iberian people of Portugal and Spain - themselves a mixture of Moor, Goth, Semite, Vandal, and other peoples - introduced into the Latin American race is here shown in its intensity, and is augmented by a further Spanish quality. The Spaniard often regards the Indians as *animals*. Other European people may have abused the Indians of America, but none have that peculiar Spanish attitude towards them of frankly considering them as non-human.[...]There is yet a further trait of the Latin American which to the Anglo-Saxon mind is almost inexplicable. This is the pleasure in the torture of the Indian as a *diversion*, not merely as a vengeance or 'punishment.'"²⁷

The explanation? That the Peruvians carry bad Iberian blood, blood of a lower class. Enock's analysis exists within a rigid racial hierarchy - even his criticism of ethnic cleansing reinforces colonial hierarchy. This is a criticism not *of*, but *internal to* the Civilising Project.

It is not surprising that, as an engineer, Enock would be chosen to introduce Hardenburg's narrative. Although Hardenburg is less explicit about his racial prejudices - he has them, but they don't shine through so vividly - he shares another interest with Enock. As they describe the natural space of the Putumayo basin and its inhabitants, they do so as surveyors and engineers, cataloging every natural and human element in terms of their potential to produce profit. Enock writes: "In the Peruvian Montaña, in its upper regions, Nature has been lavish of her products and opportunities. The rancher who should take up his abode there, with a small amount of capital, can rapidly acquire estates and wealth.... It is sufficient to cut down and burn the brush and scratch the soil and sow any seed, to

²⁵Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 16

²⁶Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 19

²⁷Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 37

recover return of a hundred for one." And a page later: "The whole Amazon Valley, when it shall have been opened up, will prove to be one of the most valuable parts of the earth's surface." What's odd about these quotes is that they are sandwiched between the diatribes against the "savages" of North and South America and the extended musings on the racial mixing of Spanish and Latin American races. It's written in a scattered way, as if Enock can't decide between the relative importance of accumulation and expounding his racial theories.

Hardenburg's account is somewhat more focused on profit, as his journey was planned explicitly as an expedition to find profitable areas of investment. He wanted to take advantage of the rubber boom, but kept a keen eye on any potentially profitable ventures. He similarly discusses the suitability of the region for agriculture, noting that "[a] part of the valley is low and swampy, but the rest is good, rich soil, quite suitable for agricultural purposes, and covered with a thick, short grass. Although all the encircling mountains are clad with forests, the valley is, at present, cleared and ready for cultivation."²⁸ As he travels down the river, he takes samples of rocks that might indicate the presence of valuable minerals.

Once Hardenburg reaches the rubber producing regions, he quickly hits it off with the Colombian rubber agents. Talking to an agent named Duarte, Hardenburg learns that "all this rubber was collected by the Indians in the Company's service, who came periodically with what they had collected and exchanged it for merchandise, &c., sold to them at rather exorbitant prices." This description hardly seems like a positive assessment of the Colombian Duarte, but it is explicitly presented as the positive complement to the maltreatment of the local inhabitants of the region by the Peruvians: "... the greatest portion of [the Huitotos] were in the service of the Peruvian Amazon Company, which, Duarte informed me, treated them very harshly, obliging them to work night and day without the slightest remuneration."

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Further anecdotes are meant to reflect well on the treatment of the Huitoto by the Colombian settlers, such as the observation that the native employees of the Colombian firms wear European clothes, but this purported concern for the welfare of the local inhabitants of the Putumayo is undermined by a description of the Christmas celebration that Hardenburg passes with the Colombian rubber men: "Then López brought out a small barrel of the indispensable *aguardiente*, and everybody, including the sick policemen, their Cioni boatmen, and Perkins and myself, got on more or less of a jag, which lasted all day, and was not interrupted even by the death of one of López' Indians, who, it seems, had been ailing for some time."²⁹

A few days after the Christmas celebration, Hardenburg entered into negotiations to purchase stock in one of the Colombian rubber companies. Unfortunately for him, the negotiations were cut short when the Peruvian Amazon Company, accompanied by Peruvian soldiers, launched a raid on the Colombian rubber settlements, massacred the workers and agents, and took Hardenburg and his traveling mate captive. It is in captivity that Hardenburg witnessed the bulk of the atrocities that would inform his report which broke the news of the Putumayo Genocide to the English speaking world. It is clear, however, that what he witnessed before he saw the atrocities, what he witnessed while meeting and dealing with the Colombian rubber agents still formed part of the erasure of indigenous life and community in the service of rubber production. The colonial hegemony imposed on the Putumayo region was upheld not only by the atrocities committed by Arana and his agents, but by the cheating of native rubber workers, the enforcing of European customs, the undermining of indigenous production, and the callous disregard for native life expressed by Hardenburg and Enock in their accounts.

²⁸Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 55

²⁹Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 134

Conclusion

Taussig refers to market pressure as a 'trigger' - not the cause of the genocide, just its context. But although the market may not have demanded the specific torture of the Huitoto people, it did demand a radical reconfiguration of life in the Putumayo. Meeting the market demand for rubber in previously unimagined quantities required a logic of extraction to be imposed on the land, and labor discipline to be imposed on the workers. And the structure of the global market made way for this imposition to be borne out by especially bloodthirsty actors.

It is crucial here to note that the bloodthirsty actors were not unopposed. This talk has been necessarily limited in scope, as my research is still in early stages. The documents which I have worked through so far are those I have mentioned in this talk: Hardenburg's narrative, Enock's introduction, and a few contemporary newspaper articles. I have collected further documents that I hope will help me to paint a fuller picture, especially in regard to true opposition to the genocide that took a genuine interest in liberation, rather than the opposition of Enock and Hardenburg that was tempered by a desire to profit off the Putumayo. Some of these actors include the Pro-Indigena Society of Peru, the British Anti-Slavery Society of Great Britain, Roger Casement, the journalist Benjamin Saldaña Rocca, and of course the people of the Putumayo themselves.

Lastly, the question I asked at the beginning of this talk remains mostly unanswered. In the Putumayo region, the changes experienced by families were almost entirely destructive. Families were not reconfigured or re-elaborated, but erased. However, as mentioned earlier, other forms of labor were developed in the Amazon during this period, and they were supported by other forms of families. The future of this portion of my research project lies in investigating these forms, from the transhumant rubber tappers who resisted proletarianization to the plantation experiments by Henry Ford and others.

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